MARKET CASE STUDY | OCTOBER 2026

India's Electric Commercial Vehicle Market

E-buses and e-LCVs: market share, competitors, government schemes and outlook to 2030

23,540	28.2%	5.91%	14,028
e-CVs sold Jan-Aug 2026 (+155%)	Switch share of e-bus registrations, H1 2026	EV share of LCV sales, Aug 2026	e-buses funded by PM E-DRIVE

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Method: secondary research (Vahan-based registration data, government scheme documents, tender results, company filings) plus a primary research plan

Data as of 16 October 2026

Contents

1. Executive summary

2. Scope, method and data notes

3. Market context

4. E-bus segment

5. E-LCV segment

6. Competitor landscape

7. Government schemes and policy

8. Unit economics: why fleets switch

9. Outlook and scenarios to 2030

10. Strategic implications and recommendations

11. Primary research plan

12. Case discussion questions

13. Sources

Exhibits

Exhibit 1: e-CV registrations by category

Exhibit 2: E-bus share by manufacturer, 2024 to H1 2026

Exhibit 3: Allocation of the 10,900-bus CESL tender

Exhibit 4: E-LCV units by manufacturer

Exhibit 5: Policy milestones

Exhibit 6: e-LCV payback sensitivity

Exhibit 7: 2030 volume scenarios

1. Executive summary

India's electric commercial vehicle (e-CV) market is heading for a record 40,000-42,000 units in 2026, about 2.5 times 2025. Retail registrations reached 23,540 in January-August 2026, up 155% year on year, against 16,695 for all of 2025 (Autocar Professional).

The two target segments behave like two different businesses:

	E-buses	E-LCVs (light goods carriers)
Volume, Jan-Aug 2026	4,556 units (+43% YoY)	17,292 units (+202% YoY)
Share of e-CV volume	19% (down from 35%)	73% (up from 62%)
Buyer	State transport undertakings (STUs) and cities, via tenders	Fleet owners, logistics firms, owner-drivers
Business model	Gross Cost Contract (GCC): OEM-operator leases the bus at a rate per km for 10-12 years	Outright purchase or lease, retail financing
Central subsidy	Yes: Rs 20-35 lakh per bus (PM E-DRIVE)	No central purchase subsidy below 3.5 t
What decides the winner	Tender price, payment security, execution capacity	TCO, range, price, dealer and finance reach
Leaders (2026 YTD)	Switch, JBM group, PMI	Tata Motors, Euler Motors, Mahindra LMM

Three findings that shape the case

1. E-bus market share lags tender wins. Switch leads H1 2026 registrations (28.2%), but PMI, EKA and Olectra won the 10,900-bus PM E-DRIVE tender. Expect the 2027-28 leaderboard to shift toward PMI and EKA.

2. E-LCVs are now a retail, TCO-led market. EV share of LCV sales doubled from 2.88% to 5.91% in twelve months, helped by diesel at about Rs 98 per litre after the May 2026 price rise.

3. Policy is shifting from subsidy to localisation and payment security. PM E-DRIVE runs to March 2028 for buses and trucks, with stricter motor localisation from September 2026 and April 2027.

The strategic question for any OEM, Switch included: how to turn a strong e-bus delivery year into the next tender cycle, while building a retail e-LCV business that does not depend on government money.

2. Scope, method and data notes

This case covers battery-electric buses (M2/M3) and light goods carriers up to about 3.5 t gross vehicle weight in India, as of mid-October 2026. Three-wheelers, cars and heavy trucks appear only as context.

Secondary research (completed). Vahan-based registration analyses (Sustainable Bus, Autocar Professional, EVreporter), Ministry of Heavy Industries and Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs scheme documents, CESL tender documents, company results and CEO interviews.

Primary research (planned). Interviews and a survey are designed in Section 11. The hypotheses in this case should be treated as untested until they are run.

Data caveats:

- Vahan counts registrations, not factory dispatches; company 'deliveries' often differ from registrations in the same period.
- Sources disagree on 2025 e-bus totals: Sustainable Bus first reported 4,441 units, later 3,961, with Switch at 950 versus 1,235. This case uses the later, revised series.
- Calendar year (CY, Jan-Dec) and Indian fiscal year (FY, Apr-Mar) are both used. FY26 = April 2025 to March 2026.
- Company claims (for example, 'over 80% share of the 2-3.5 t e-LCV band') are shown as claims, not market facts.

3. Market context

Electric is still a small slice of India's commercial vehicle fleet, but it now grows faster in goods than in passengers. Light goods carriers added 11,566 of the extra units sold in January-August 2026.

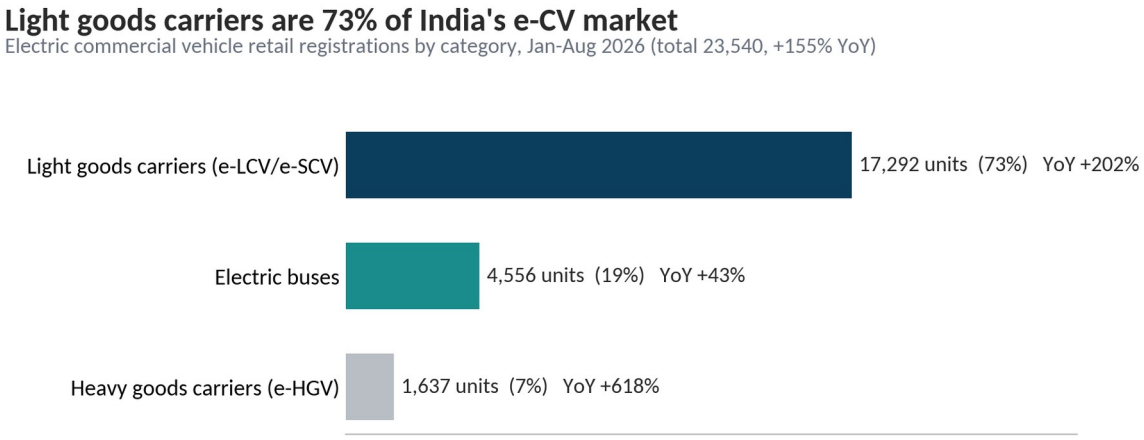


Exhibit 1: India e-CV registrations by category, Jan-Aug 2026

Penetration shows the headroom:

- **Buses:** about 4% of annual bus registrations were electric in FY25. India has roughly 8 e-buses per million people against a global average near 94 (CareEdge via Saur Energy).
- **LCVs:** 643,470 LCVs were registered in the 12 months to August 2026. EV share averaged 3.46% and reached 5.91% in August 2026; diesel still made up about 75% of volume (EVreporter).

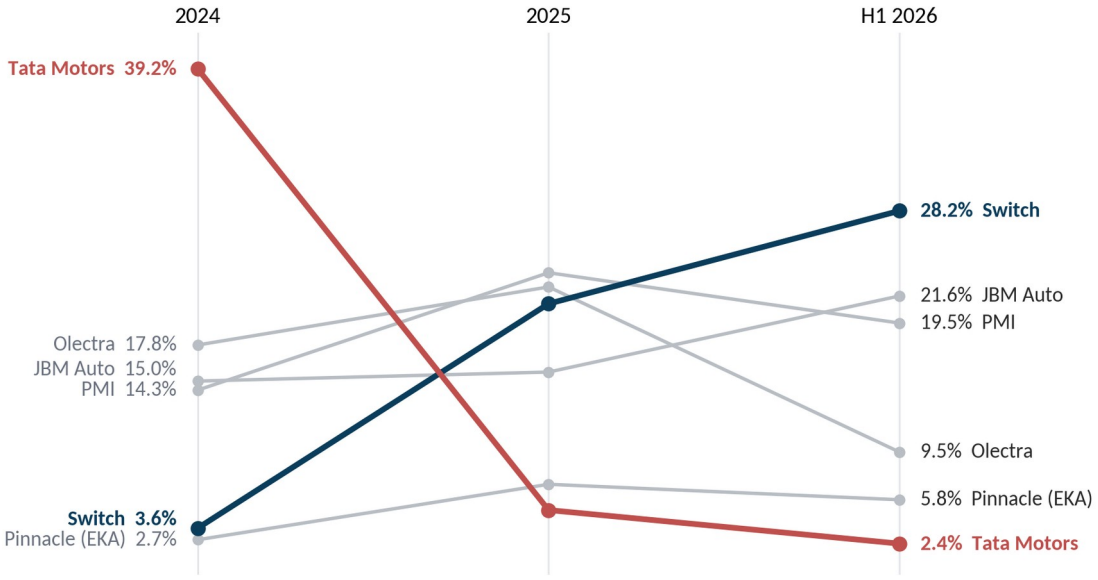
Two external shocks matter in 2026. Brent crude rose from under $70 in January to over $108 by mid-September, and diesel in Mumbai went from about Rs 87.67 to Rs 97.83 per litre after the 14 May hike. Both strengthen the electric running-cost case for fleet operators.

4. E-bus segment

India registered 2,944 electric buses in H1 2026, up 40% on H1 2025, and the top three makers took 70% (Sustainable Bus). Leadership changes hands every year because volume follows tender wins, not retail demand.

Switch rose to 28.2% of e-bus registrations; Tata fell to 2.4%

Share of India electric bus registrations by manufacturer (%)



Source: Sustainable Bus analysis of Vahan data (6 Jul 2026). JBM Electric Vehicles (5.7% in H1 2026) reported separately; JBM group combined 27.3%.

Exhibit 2: E-bus registration share by manufacturer, 2024 to H1 2026

Tata Motors held 39.2% in 2024 and 2.4% in H1 2026. Analysts link the fall to Tata stepping back from aggressive tender bids over contract terms and payment security. Switch's rise reflects delivery of orders won in 2023-24, including a 950-bus GCC contract.

4.1 How e-buses are bought: the GCC model

Almost all e-buses are leased, not sold. Under a **Gross Cost Contract (GCC)** the OEM or its operating arm buys the bus and charger, runs and maintains it for 10-12 years, and is paid a fixed rate per km. The city keeps fare revenue and usually supplies the conductor. The OEM becomes a long-term operator that needs cheap capital, depots and power connections.

What cities pay, from recent Bengaluru contracts:

Contract	Bus type	Rate (Rs/km)
TML Smart City Mobility (Tata) for BMTC	12 m, non-AC, low-floor	40.01
BMTC 148-bus lot, 12-year GCC incl. electricity	12 m	41.01
Ohm Global Mobility (Ashok Leyland) for BMTC	12 m, AC, low-floor	65.80
Switch Mobility bid (rejected as too high)	8-10 m midi	86.00

Source: Deccan Herald reporting on BMTC tenders.

The midi-bus case is a lesson in itself: small buses on short feeder routes cost more per km, and a sole bidder could not reach the price the city would pay.

4.2 The tenders that set the next two years

CESL ran India's largest e-bus tender: 10,900 buses on GCC for Bengaluru (4,500), Delhi (2,800), Hyderabad (2,000), Ahmedabad (1,000) and Surat (600) under PM E-DRIVE.

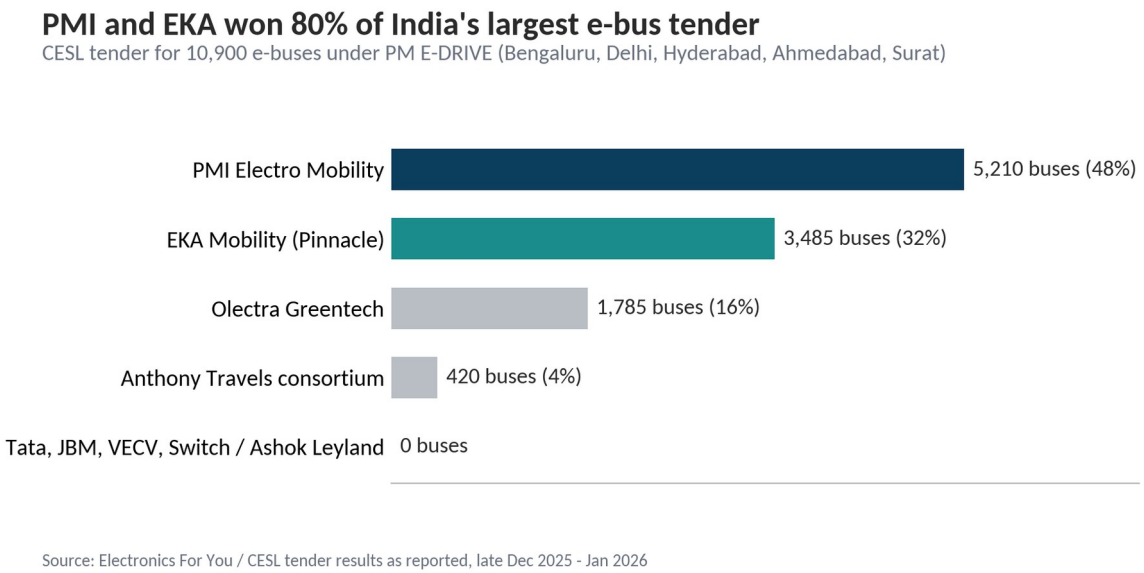


Exhibit 3: Allocation of the 10,900-bus CESL tender

Ashok Leyland's bid was reported as not successfully submitted, and its subsidiary Ohm Global Mobility challenged this in the Delhi High Court. For Switch, the PM E-DRIVE pipeline largely bypasses it; growth must come from state tenders, PM-eBus Sewa and private fleets.

In parallel, **PM-eBus Sewa** targets 10,000 e-buses in smaller cities. By March 2026, letters of award covered 5,612 buses across 77 cities, and the first four cities (Guwahati, Bhavnagar, Nagpur, Chandigarh) started operations in February 2026. JBM won 1,021 buses worth about Rs 5,500 crore in its second round.

5. E-LCV segment

Electric light goods carriers are the fastest-growing e-CV category: 17,292 units in January-August 2026, already above all of 2025 (11,155). Autocar Professional expects more than 25,000 for the year. Demand comes from hub-and-spoke urban delivery: e-commerce, FMCG, white goods, parcel and organised retail.

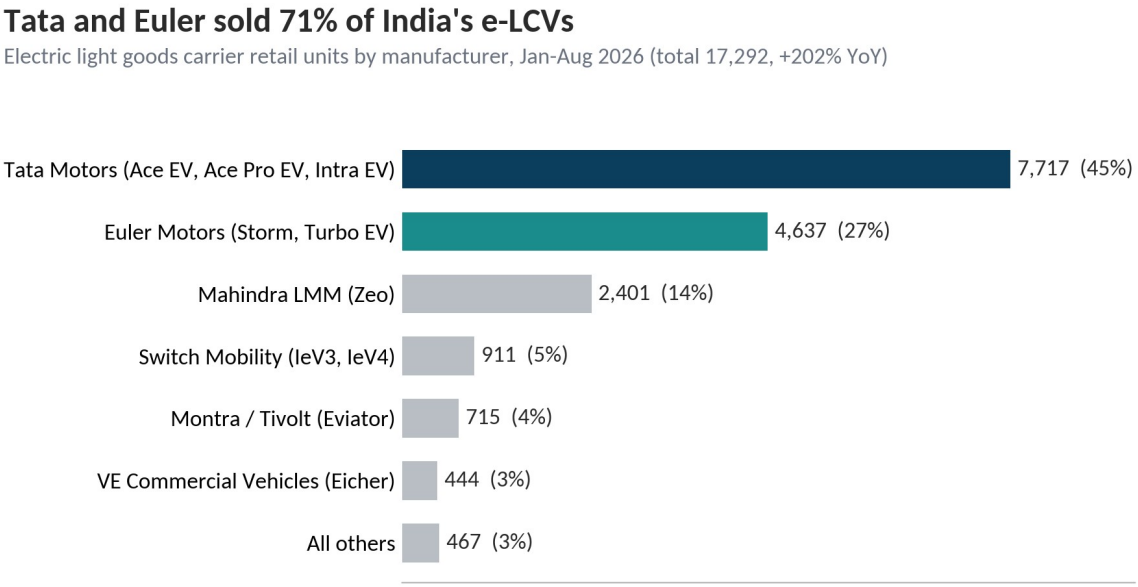


Exhibit 4: E-LCV retail units by manufacturer, Jan-Aug 2026

Euler Motors, backed by Hero MotoCorp, grew 1,305% and overtook Mahindra for number two. Mahindra grew only 52% on a single model, the Zeo. Over the 12 months to August 2026, the top three makers held about 85% of e-LCV registrations.

Why this segment grows without a central subsidy:

- **Running cost:** about Rs 1.5-2 per km on electricity versus Rs 8-10 per km on diesel for goods carriers.
- **Fixed urban routes:** daily runs of 80-120 km fit a 120-160 km real-world range with overnight depot charging.
- **Anchor fleets:** Flipkart, Amazon and Swiggy are building electric last-mile fleets, giving lessors volume to finance against.
- **Price convergence:** the Tata Ace Pro EV at about Rs 6.5 lakh sits close to diesel and CNG small trucks.

Adoption is uneven by state. Tata led Rajasthan (790 units, January-July 2026), while Euler led Delhi (530 versus Tata's 341).

5.1 Products on sale

Model	Maker	Ex-showroom price	Battery / range	Positioning
Ace Pro EV	Tata Motors	Rs 6.50 lakh	100-120 km per charge	Entry mini-truck, price-led
Ace EV	Tata Motors	Rs 10.51 lakh	21.3 kWh LFP, 154 km	Original e-SCV, fleet contracts
Ace EV 1000	Tata Motors	Rs 11.30-11.50 lakh	1 t payload	Higher-payload Ace
Zeo	Mahindra LMM	Rs 7.88-8.47 lakh	160 km real-world; 7-yr/150,000 km battery warranty	Mid-price, warranty-led
Turbo EV 1000	Euler Motors	Rs 6.00-8.35 lakh	Long-range variant	Price-led, fleet leasing
Storm EV	Euler Motors	Rs 9.00-13.00 lakh	T1500 and LR 200 variants	Larger body, intra-city
Eviator 350 / 350L+	Montra (Murugappa)	Not published	32 kWh (140 km) / 50 kWh (300 km)	Range-led, reefer, intercity
IeV3 / IeV4	Switch Mobility	Not published	1.25 t / 1.75 t payload	Ashok Leyland dealers; IeV4 Reefer
Pro X EV	Eicher (VECV)	Rs 16.99-17.99 lakh	2-3.5 t GVW class	Upper LCV, premium

Prices are indicative dealer-portal listings (Delhi, 2026) and vary by variant and city.

Tata and Euler compete on price at the bottom, Montra and Switch on payload, range and special bodies, and Eicher at the top of the weight band. Switch claims more than 80% share of the 2-3.5 t electric band, a self-defined band that excludes the lighter class where Tata and Mahindra compete.

6. Competitor landscape

Ten companies matter in these two segments, and only Switch and Tata play seriously in both. Sorted by 2026 e-CV volume.

Company (parent)	Segments	2026 position and key numbers	Main strength	Main gap
Tata Motors	e-LCV, e-bus, e-truck	No. 1 e-CV (33%): 7,867 units Jan-Aug 2026; e-bus share 2.4%	Dealer and finance reach, widest e-LCV range	Stepped back from GCC bus tenders
Euler Motors (Hero-backed)	e-LCV	No. 2 e-CV (20%): 4,637 units, +1,305%	Price, fleet leasing, fast scale-up	Single segment, startup balance sheet
Mahindra Last Mile Mobility	e-LCV	No. 3 e-LCV (14%): 2,401 Zeo, +52%	Brand, warranty, network	One model; losing share
Switch Mobility (Ashok Leyland)	e-bus, e-LCV	No. 1 e-bus H1 2026 (28.2%); FY26 revenue ~Rs 1,800 cr, first net profit	Execution, 60-70% localisation, ~98% uptime	Missed 10,900-bus PM E-DRIVE tender
JBM Auto / JBM Ecolife	e-bus	No. 2 e-bus (group 27.3%); order book 10,000+; 20,000/yr plant	Capacity and capital (Rs 750 cr raised)	No CESL 10,900 allocation
PMI Electro Mobility	e-bus	No. 3 e-bus (19.5%); 5,210 CESL buses	Lowest-cost GCC bidding	Execution risk on a 5x jump
Olectra Greentech (MEIL)	e-bus, e-tipper	9.5% e-bus; FY26 revenue Rs 2,312 cr, PAT Rs 179.5 cr; 1,785 CESL buses	Listed pure-play, large backlog	Slow backlog conversion
EKA Mobility (Pinnacle)	e-bus, e-LCV	5.8% e-bus; 3,485 CESL buses	Tender wins, partner model	Small installed base
Montra / Tivolt (Murugappa)	e-LCV, e-truck	3% e-CV: 715 units, +686%	Range options (32-50 kWh)	Late entrant
VE Commercial Vehicles	e-LCV, e-bus	589 e-CVs (444 e-SCV, 145 e-bus)	Upper-LCV and bus brand	Premium price, low volume

6.1 Switch Mobility in focus

Switch shows how an incumbent's EV arm reached profit. Its CEO points to a narrow product set (two bus platforms, two e-LCVs), 60-70% localisation and about 98% fleet uptime, which protects per-km GCC earnings. In FY26 it delivered 1,530 e-buses and 1,600 e-LCVs.

Its risks are just as clear:

- **Pipeline gap:** it began FY27 with about 1,600 buses on order, against more than 10,000 at JBM and about 8,500 at Olectra.
- **Pricing discipline:** its Rs 86/km midi-bus bid in Bengaluru was rejected; a 12 m AC bus from sister firm Ohm went at Rs 65.8/km.
- **E-LCV scale:** 911 e-LCVs in January-August 2026 is about 5% of the segment.

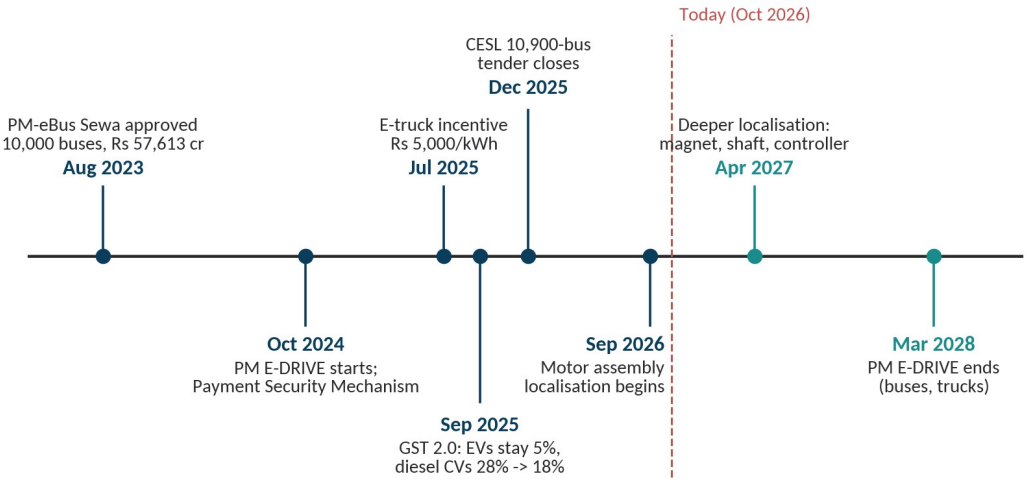
Management plans to grow private orders (staff, intercity, school and airport tarmac) alongside STU tenders and reinvest at least 10% of revenue in products and capacity.

7. Government schemes and policy

Central support now flows mainly to buses and trucks. E-LCVs under 3.5 t get the 5% GST rate but no central purchase subsidy.

Policy is moving from purchase subsidy to localisation and payment security

Key milestones for e-buses and e-LCVs in India



Sources: MoHUA, Ministry of Heavy Industries notifications, GST Council, CESL; see Sources section.

Exhibit 5: Policy milestones for e-buses and e-LCVs

Scheme	Period and outlay	For e-buses	For e-LCVs
PM E-DRIVE (Ministry of Heavy Industries)	Oct 2024 - Mar 2028 for buses and trucks; Rs 11,900 cr	Rs 4,391 cr for 14,028 buses in 9 large cities; Rs 35 / 25 / 20 lakh per standard / midi / mini bus	None below 3.5 t
PM E-DRIVE e-truck incentive	From July 2025	Not applicable	Only above 3.5 t: Rs 5,000/kWh or 10% of price, up to Rs 9.6 lakh
PM-eBus Sewa (MoHUA)	10 years of operations; Rs 57,613 cr (Rs 20,000 cr central)	10,000 buses on PPP/GCC in cities of 3 lakh+; depots and power	None
Payment Security Mechanism (CESL)	From Oct 2024; Rs 3,435 cr	Pays operators if a city defaults; state guarantee via RBI direct debit	None
GST 2.0	From 22 Sep 2025	EVs stay at 5%	EVs 5%; diesel LCVs and buses cut from 28% to 18%
Phased Manufacturing Programme	Sep 2026 and Apr 2027 milestones	Motor assembly in India, then magnet, shaft and controller	Applies to N2/N3 trucks, not N1

Four takeaways:

1. **The bus subsidy is a capital grant passed through tenders.** It lowers the per-km rate the operator can bid, so tender design matters more than headline outlay.
2. **Payment security fixed the bus makers' biggest fear.** It makes GCC contracts bankable, which is why JBM could raise Rs 750 crore against its order book.
3. **GST 2.0 narrowed the EV tax edge.** The gap fell from 23 points (5% vs 28%) to 13 points (5% vs 18%); e-LCVs now win on running cost, not tax.
4. **Localisation raises the bar for importers.** Rare-earth magnet shortages pushed the deeper motor rules to April 2027; OEMs with Indian motor supply gain an edge.

8. Unit economics: why fleets switch

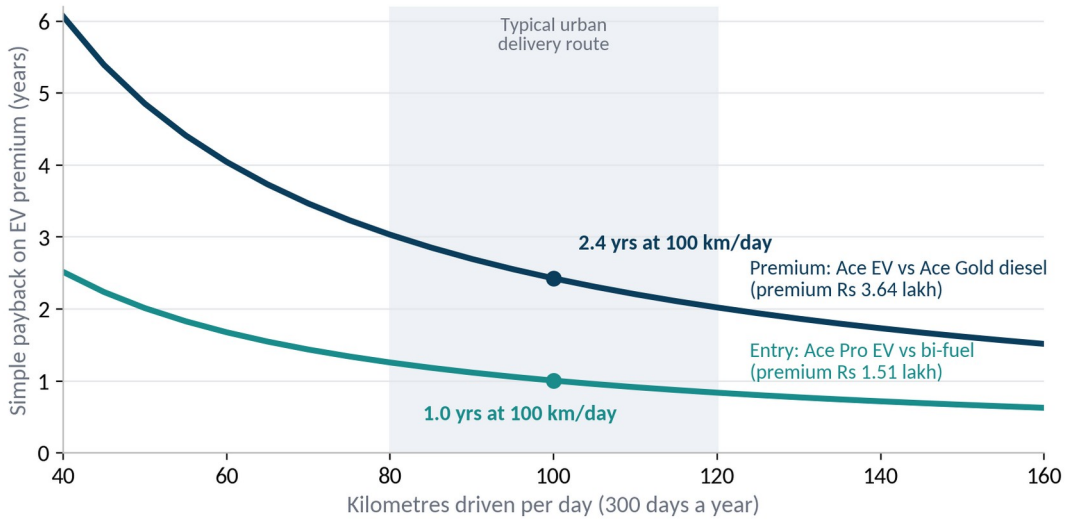
At 100 km a day, an entry e-LCV pays back its price premium in about one year on energy savings alone; a premium e-LCV takes about 2.4 years. E-buses beat diesel only at high daily use, which is why they are bought per km rather than per bus.

Simple payback (years) = (EV price - ICE price) / ((ICE cost per km - EV cost per km) x km per day x days per year)

Input	Entry: Ace Pro EV vs bi-fuel	Premium: Ace EV vs Ace Gold diesel
EV price	Rs 6.50 lakh	Rs 10.51 lakh
ICE price	Rs 4.99 lakh	Rs 6.87 lakh (top variant)
Price premium	Rs 1.51 lakh	Rs 3.64 lakh
ICE energy cost	Rs 6.5/km (diesel Rs 97.83/l at 15 km/l)	Rs 6.5/km
EV energy cost	Rs 1.5/km (~0.14 kWh/km at Rs 9-10/kWh plus losses)	Rs 1.5/km
Saving per year (100 km/day, 300 days)	Rs 1.50 lakh	Rs 1.50 lakh
Simple payback	**~1.0 year**	**~2.4 years**

At 100 km a day, an entry e-LCV pays back its premium in about a year

Simple payback = price premium / (energy saving per km x km per year); diesel Rs 6.5/km vs electric Rs 1.5/km



Source: case author's illustrative model; prices from dealer listings (2026), diesel Rs 97.83/l (Mumbai). Excludes finance, maintenance and resale.

Exhibit 6: Payback sensitivity to daily kilometres (illustrative model)

Daily kilometres drive the answer. At 60 km a day payback stretches to about 1.7 and 4 years, which is why fleet operators on fixed, high-use routes switch first and owner-drivers follow later. Higher loan rates and weaker EV resale push payback out further.

8.1 E-bus economics

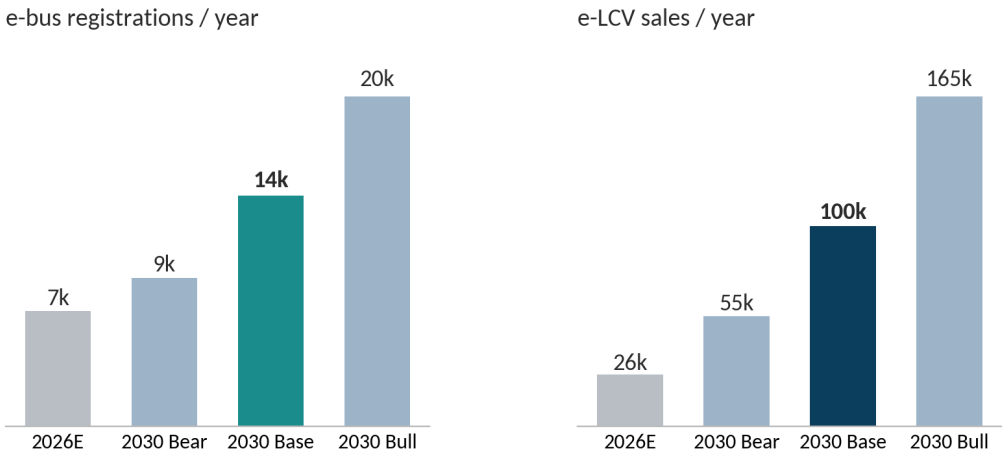
An e-bus costs more to buy and far less to run. One published model (ForeSee Advisors, 72,000 km a year) puts year-one operating cost at Rs 34.5/km for electric against Rs 57/km for diesel, and finds electric about 17% cheaper per km over the full life. An older WRI India study found the opposite at 200 km a day (Rs 60.47/km electric versus Rs 44.30/km low-cost diesel). The answer depends on bus price, battery life, utilisation and the cost of capital; the PM E-DRIVE grant and payment security lower the last two, which made GCC rates of Rs 40-66/km possible in Bengaluru.

9. Outlook and scenarios to 2030

The base case is about 14,000 e-buses and 100,000 e-LCVs a year by 2030, roughly double and four times 2026 levels. These are the author's estimates built from the pipeline and penetration data and should be tested in the primary research.

Base case: ~14,000 e-buses and ~100,000 e-LCVs a year by 2030

Case author's scenarios; 2026E from Jan-Aug run-rate and Autocar Professional forecast



Assumptions: e-LCV share of ~650k LCVs/yr at 8% / 15% / 25%; e-bus pipeline of ~21k buses under central schemes plus state tenders.

Exhibit 7: Annual volume scenarios for 2030

Scenario (2030)	e-bus / year	e-LCV share	What has to happen
Bear	~9,000	~8% (~55,000)	PM E-DRIVE money runs out early; diesel prices fall back; city payments slip
Base	**~14,000**	**~15% (~100,000)**	Current tenders delivered on time; follow-on bus scheme after 2028; e-LCV prices keep falling
Bull	~20,000	~25% (~165,000)	National bus target extended; cheap fleet finance; low-emission zones for goods vehicles

About 21,000 buses are already in central programmes (10,900 CESL plus 10,000 PM-eBus Sewa). The top four OEMs had about 32,000 units a year of capacity and an order book near 31,000 units in late FY26, so capacity is not the constraint; tender timing, depots and power connections are. Published forecasts point the same way: the e-bus market growing from about $1.0 bn in 2025 to $3.4 bn by 2031 (21.5% a year, Ken Research) and the e-LCV market from $94 mn in FY26 to $518 mn by FY31 (40.8% a year, MarqStats).

Swing factors to watch:

- **Life after PM E-DRIVE:** payments stop on 31 March 2028, earlier if funds run out.
- **Battery and magnet supply:** rare-earth export limits already delayed localisation; LFP cell prices set e-LCV price parity.
- **Fuel prices:** a fall back below $75 Brent would slow owner-driver adoption.

- **Consolidation:** Tata's takeover of Iveco and new capital into JBM and EKA may reshape the bus field.
- **CNG competition:** CNG small trucks remain cheapest to buy, and GST 2.0 made them cheaper.

10. Strategic implications and recommendations

The winners by 2030 will be OEMs that can operate buses cheaply on contract and sell e-LCVs through retail finance.

Who	Recommendation	Why
E-bus OEMs	Compete on cost per km: uptime, energy management, depot design	GCC pays per km; a 2% uptime gap is lost revenue for 12 years
E-bus OEMs	Build or partner for an operating and financing arm	JBM (Rs 750 cr) and EKA (with Chartered Speed) show the model
E-bus OEMs	Localise traction motors and controllers before April 2027	Decides subsidy eligibility in the next tender round
E-LCV OEMs	Price within about Rs 1.5 lakh of the CNG/diesel equivalent	Keeps payback near one year at typical urban use
E-LCV OEMs	Tie up with lenders; offer battery buy-back or guaranteed resale	Finance cost and resale fear are the main owner-driver barriers
E-LCV OEMs	Build a second and third model	Mahindra's single-model position shows the limit
Policymakers	Plan the post-2028 bus programme now	Tender pipelines need 18-24 months' notice

10.1 For Switch Mobility

1. **Refill the bus pipeline:** target PM-eBus Sewa, state STU tenders and private staff and intercity fleets; resolve the CESL bid issue before the next central round.
2. **Bring cost per km down:** use Ashok Leyland's scale and Ohm's operating data to bid within the Rs 40-66/km band.
3. **Turn the e-LCV niche into a platform:** keep the 2-3.5 t and cold-chain position, and add a lower-priced model to compete for volume.
4. **Use profitability to raise capital:** first-year profit and a 10%-of-revenue reinvestment plan make the case for outside funding, as JBM did.

11. Primary research plan

About 25 interviews and a 100-response survey over four weeks would test the five hypotheses this case rests on.

#	Hypothesis	Who to ask	Method
H1	Payback under 2 years at 80+ km/day drives e-LCV purchase	Fleet owners, owner-drivers	Survey + 8 interviews
H2	Finance cost and resale fear, not range, are the main barriers	NBFCs, lessors, dealers	5 interviews
H3	GCC per-km rate is set by cost of capital and uptime more than bus price	STU officials, OEM bid teams	5 interviews
H4	Payment security has made STUs bankable	Banks, CESL, operators	3 interviews
H5	Depot power connections are the main delivery bottleneck	Operators, DISCOMs, depot managers	4 interviews + 2 depot visits

11.1 Interview guide: fleet owners (45 minutes)

1. What routes and daily kilometres do your vehicles run, and how many days a month?
2. When did you last buy a vehicle, what did you compare, and why that fuel?
3. What does diesel or CNG cost you per vehicle per month? What would make you switch?
4. How did you finance it (rate, tenure)? Did the lender treat an EV differently?
5. What resale value do you expect, and how sure are you?
6. Where would you charge, and what happens on a day you run 30% more?
7. If you run an EV: what surprised you, good and bad, in the first six months?

11.2 Interview guide: STUs, cities and OEM bid teams

1. How do you set the reserve per-km rate in a GCC tender?
2. What made you choose or reject bidders in the last round?
3. How long do payments take, and has the payment security mechanism changed that?
4. What delays deliveries most: buses, chargers, depots or power?
5. What happens to your fleet plans after March 2028?

11.3 Survey design

100 owner-drivers and small fleets in Delhi, Bengaluru, Jaipur and Hyderabad, split between EV users and diesel/CNG users. Core questions: fleet size; average km/day; fuel spend per month; top three purchase criteria (ranked); maximum acceptable EV price premium; preferred finance tenure and EMI; likelihood of switching in 12 months (1-5).

Deliverables: a one-page finding per hypothesis, an updated TCO model with real kilometres and finance terms, and a revised 2030 scenario table.

12. Case discussion questions

1. Switch led e-bus registrations in H1 2026 but won none of the 10,900-bus PM E-DRIVE tender. Is its leadership durable, and what would you do in its FY28 plan?
2. Tata Motors stepped back from GCC bus tenders while doubling down on e-LCVs. Was that right, and what would bring it back?
3. PMI and EKA won 80% of the largest tender. What risks does a fivefold volume jump create for them and for the cities relying on them?
4. Euler grew 1,305% with no central subsidy. What does that say about where public money should go next?
5. GST 2.0 cut diesel CV tax from 28% to 18% while EVs stayed at 5%. Should the EV rate fall further, or is the running-cost edge enough?
6. As head of a city transport undertaking, would you buy buses outright or lease them on GCC? What would change your answer?
7. Design the post-March 2028 bus programme. What would you keep from PM E-DRIVE and PM-eBus Sewa, and what would you change?

13. Sources

All accessed 16 October 2026.

Market data

- India's electric bus registrations grow 40% in H1 2026 - Sustainable Bus, 6 Jul 2026
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